

Trapped in Shadows

Moral angst takes centrestage as a journalist follows the murder of a moneylender in a remote village



SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodaymag.com

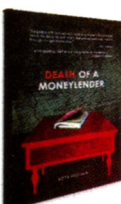
By Geeta Doctor

It is a portentous title. For all those who have until now fastened upon Pran, the smooth-tongued villain of countless Hindi movies, as the archetype of the greedy, grasping moneylender, it provides a salutary lesson. Do not judge men by their exterior, or by their profession, or a book by its title. There is more to moneylending than you could possibly imagine.

As someone remarks in the course of the story, it's the farmers who commit suicide, not the moneylenders. Haven't we all seen the gaunt, grizzled faces of the cotton farmers of Vidharbha and those in Andhra Pradesh staring out of their marriage portraits, or ration card images, as the restless eye of the electronic age ranges over their grieving families and politicians swoop down with a consolatory dole as they become another statistic or rural despair? The earth is dying beneath their feet. This is not "The Good Earth" of a Pearl S. Buck era but the poisoned spring of a Rachel Carson, where the lessons of too much intervention in the form of pesticides and political power have become as familiar a part of the farming life as acid rain.

Kota Neelima is not content to flip the channel and move on. She belongs to an old-fashioned breed of persons working in the media. She cares. Or at least she makes her hero, Falak, a journalist who has been despatched by his editor to cover the death of a moneylender in a remote village, ponder deeply about the things that exist between him and his deadline. This is the stuff of a thousand pages of edit page angst about rural debt, the yawning chasm between 'us' and 'them'.

If you try and ignore the idea that the author has the shadow of Garcia Marquez sitting like a vulture on the shoulder of Falak, as he whinges his way into a dusty old village in the heart of nowhere in search of a death foretold to him by his editor, naturally a heartless clone of Pran in a newer garb, there is something wholly admirable about the enterprise. He's given an ex-girlfriend Vani, who is also desperately seeking the story for a rival newspaper and a couple of photographers to add a little fizz. Neelima's observer remains forever trapped in the shadows, waiting to fulfil his deadline, rather than his destiny. ■



DEATH OF A MONEYLENDER
by KOTA NEELIMA
Indialink/Roli
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 220

Noble Plot

A murder mystery set in the Mughal era

By Sonya Dutta Choudhury

Twenty-five-year-old nobleman Muzaffar Jang hates parties. He wears no jewellery, has no embroidery on his rich green *chogha* and counts among his friends, Faisal the jeweller, Salim the boatman, and Shafi, the attar man. But he will soon enough turn detective in this Mughal murder mystery. Jang lives in 17th century Shahjahanabad, in the city of Dilli. Delhiites will recognise present day Delhi in the references to the *kotwali* (police station) at Chandni Chowk, the havelis of the rich and the famous and the cluttered bazaars full of tradesmen. It's in this carefully constructed historical landscape that nobleman Murad Begh is found dead and our maverick hero is drawn in—prime accused in the murder is friend Faisal. So he embarks, Poirot style, on a series of interviews.

First-time author Madhulika Liddle dresses up her plot immaculately, and the exoticism of the interviewees (a shift eunuch, beautiful courtesans and a Venetian merchant) is surpassed only by the clues themselves—an ivory-tipped arrow, amethyst and silver pendants, a silver *paandaan* where cardamom, aniseed and musk are mixed into betel leaves, and then finally the Englishman's cameo. Interesting enough. Except that in a

story where Mehtab Banu, the courtesan, "dabs languidly at her forehead" and Khan Sahib, the *kotwal*, "enquires sardonically", sleekness and speed are clearly not keywords. Still, there is atmosphere—with many long descriptions and the liberal use of Urdu words. ■



THE ENGLISHMAN'S CAMEO
by MADHULIKA LIDDLE
Hachette India
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 279